

UNIT 6: MASTERY - STYLE, REGISTER & PRECISION

GRAMMAR

Grammar: Subjunctive Mood & Formal Structures

The Subjunctive: Expresses wishes, hypotheticals, demands, and formal recommendations. Uses the BASE form of the verb (no -s, no past tense).

After suggestion/demand verbs: The committee recommended that he resign immediately. It is essential that every candidate submit their application by Friday.

Formulaic subjunctive: God save the King. Long live the Republic. Be that as it may. Come what may.

Were-subjunctive: If I were to accept the offer, I would need to relocate. Were she to apply, she would certainly be shortlisted.

Nominalization: Converting verbs/adjectives into nouns for formal tone. The company FAILED -> The failure of the company... He DECIDED quickly -> His swift decision...

Hedging language: It would appear that... / It could be argued that... The evidence suggests... / There is a tendency for...

Examples:

- *It is imperative that all delegates be present for the vote.*
- *Were the proposal to be accepted, significant changes would follow.*
- *The rapid deterioration of negotiations led to the collapse of the agreement.*
- *It could be argued that the policy, while well-intentioned, proved counterproductive.*

VOCABULARY

Word / Phrase	Definition
equivocal	open to more than one interpretation; uncertain
perspicacious	having a ready insight; shrewd
obfuscate	to make unclear or confusing
exacerbate	to make a problem or situation worse
ameliorate	to make something bad better; to improve
predicated on	based on or grounded in a particular premise
circumspect	cautious; taking everything into account
propensity	a natural tendency to behave in a certain way
perfunctory	carried out with minimal effort; routine
inimitable	so good it cannot be copied; unique

READING TEXT

The philosophical debate surrounding free will has, for centuries, resisted resolution. Determinists contend that every human action is the inevitable consequence of prior causes - that the notion of genuine choice is, at best, equivocal. Compatibilists argue that free will and determinism are not mutually exclusive; it is possible to be both causally determined and meaningfully free. What is striking is that this dichotomy persists despite advances in neuroscience, which have done little to ameliorate the uncertainty. Were we to accept the determinist position wholesale, the implications for moral responsibility and social policy would be profound. It is essential, therefore, that this question be approached with the circumspection it demands, rather than the perfunctory dismissal it so often receives in popular discourse.

EXERCISES: MULTIPLE CHOICE QUESTIONS

1. What is the determinist position on free will?

- A) Humans have complete freedom of choice.
- B) Free will and determinism can coexist.
- C) Every action is an inevitable result of prior causes.
- D) Neuroscience has resolved the debate.

2. What does 'ameliorate' mean in context?

- A) Worsen
- B) Ignore
- C) Improve or reduce
- D) Confirm

3. Identify the subjunctive form:

- A) It is important that she submits the form.
- B) It is essential that this question be approached carefully.
- C) She should submits her application.
- D) It is necessary that he will attend.

4. Which word means 'making something unclear or confusing'?

- A) ameliorate
- B) circumspect
- C) obfuscate
- D) predicated

5. The author's attitude to 'popular discourse' is:

- A) Enthusiastic
- B) Neutral
- C) Dismissive
- D) Mildly critical

Answer Key: Q1: C | Q2: C | Q3: B | Q4: C | Q5: D

WRITING TASK

Write a formal essay (280-320 words) on ONE of the following: (a) 'Advances in AI exacerbate existing social inequalities rather than ameliorate them.' (b) 'It is essential that higher education be made universally accessible.' Requirements: subjunctive x2, nominalization x3, hedging language, 4 vocabulary items from this sheet.

SPEAKING PRACTICE

1. Deliver a 3-minute argument: 'Were determinism true, the concept of justice would be incoherent.'
2. Analyse register: Take an informal paragraph and rewrite it formally using nominalization and hedging.
3. Discuss: 'The propensity of modern media to obfuscate rather than illuminate is the defining challenge of our era.'

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